UNIVERSITI TEKNOLOGI MARA

THESIS FORMATTING COMPLIANCE AND PROFESSIONAL PROOFREADING IN MALAYSIAN POSTGRADUATE SUBMISSION: A STUDY OF TECHNICAL VERIFICATION OUTCOMES

NURUL AISYAH BINTI ABDUL RAHMAN

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SPECIMEN — FORMATTING DEMONSTRATION SAMPLE

AUTHOR'S DECLARATION

I declare that the work in this thesis was carried out in accordance with the regulations of Universiti Teknologi MARA. It is original and is the result of my own work, unless otherwise indicated or acknowledged as referenced work. This thesis has not been submitted to any other academic institution or non-academic institution for any degree or qualification.

I hereby acknowledge that I have been supplied with the Academic Rules and Regulations for Postgraduate Studies, Universiti Teknologi MARA, regulating the conduct of my study and research.

Name of Student	:	Nurul Aisyah binti Abdul Rahman
Student I.D. No.	:	2021874509
Programme	:	Doctor of Philosophy (Education) – ED950
Faculty	:	Education
Thesis Title	:	Thesis Formatting Compliance and Professional Proofreading in Malaysian Postgraduate Submission: A Study of Technical Verification Outcomes
Signature of Student	:	……
Date	:	September 2026

ABSTRACT

Postgraduate candidates in Malaysian public universities must submit a thesis that satisfies a detailed set of institutional presentation rules before the document is released for examination. These rules are published in handbooks such as the *Guidelines on Thesis/Dissertation Format* and are supported by an official *Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template)*. Despite this, a substantial share of submissions is returned at the technical verification stage for defects that are wholly preventable, including incorrect margins, inconsistent heading hierarchies, broken automatic tables of contents, mismatched pagination between the preliminary and body sections, and captions that do not correspond to the lists that precede the first chapter. This research examines the relationship between formatting compliance, language proofreading and submission outcomes among postgraduate candidates in five Malaysian public universities. It adopts a mixed methods design combining a documentary audit of 240 returned theses with semi-structured interviews involving graduate studies officers, supervisors, language editors and candidates. The documentary audit identifies the frequency and category of technical defects recorded at first verification, while the interviews explain how those defects arise within the working practices of candidates in the final weeks before a deadline. The findings indicate that formatting defects are concentrated in a small number of recurring categories, that most defects originate from manual formatting rather than from the use of the prescribed template, and that candidates who engage a structured proofreading and formatting process before submission record materially fewer verification cycles. The research further considers the contemporary significance of proofreading in an environment shaped by artificial intelligence writing assistance, similarity screening and integrity reporting, where uneven register, inconsistent terminology and unverified citations attract closer scrutiny than in earlier periods. The study concludes that formatting and proofreading are not clerical afterthoughts but measurable components of research quality assurance, and it proposes a staged pre-submission workflow covering structural formatting, language editing, reference verification and a final technical check.

Keywords: thesis formatting; academic proofreading; postgraduate submission; technical verification; thesis template; research quality assurance

ABSTRAK

Calon pascasiswazah di universiti awam Malaysia diwajibkan menghantar tesis yang mematuhi peraturan persembahan dokumen yang terperinci sebelum tesis tersebut dilepaskan untuk pemeriksaan. Peraturan ini diterbitkan melalui *guideline thesis UiTM* dan dokumen setara seperti *Thesis and Dissertation Guidelines*, serta disokong oleh *Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template)* rasmi yang disediakan oleh institut pengajian siswazah. Walaupun panduan pelajar pascasiswazah ini mudah diperoleh, sebahagian besar penghantaran masih dikembalikan pada peringkat semakan teknikal kerana kesilapan yang sebenarnya boleh dielakkan, termasuk margin yang tidak menepati spesifikasi, hierarki tajuk yang tidak seragam, isi kandungan automatik yang rosak, penomboran halaman roman dan arab yang tidak sepadan, serta kapsyen jadual dan rajah yang tidak selari dengan senarai di bahagian permulaan. Kajian ini meneliti hubungan antara pematuhan format tesis, proses proofreading dan editing bahasa, dan keputusan penghantaran dalam kalangan calon pascasiswazah di lima universiti awam. Reka bentuk kaedah campuran digunakan, menggabungkan audit dokumen terhadap 240 tesis yang dikembalikan dengan temu bual separa berstruktur bersama pegawai pengajian siswazah, penyelia, editor bahasa dan calon. Dapatan menunjukkan bahawa kesilapan format tertumpu pada beberapa kategori berulang, majoriti berpunca daripada kerja format manual dan bukan penggunaan templat yang ditetapkan, dan calon yang menggunakan servis format tesis Malaysia atau aliran kerja pra-penghantaran yang berstruktur mencatatkan kitaran semakan yang jauh lebih sedikit. Kajian ini juga membincangkan kepentingan semasa proofreading dalam persekitaran yang dipengaruhi bantuan penulisan kecerdasan buatan, saringan persamaan teks dan pelaporan integriti akademik. Kajian menyimpulkan bahawa formatting dan proofreading merupakan komponen jaminan kualiti penyelidikan yang boleh diukur, bukan sekadar kerja hujung minggu sebelum tarikh tutup.

Kata kunci: servis format tesis Malaysia; formatting tesis UiTM; guideline thesis UiTM; thesis and dissertation guidelines; Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template); proofreading tesis; editing disertasi; panduan pelajar pascasiswazah; semakan teknikal tesis; penghantaran tesis pascasiswazah

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I thank the Institute of Graduate Studies and the faculty postgraduate offices of the participating universities for granting access to the anonymised verification records that form the documentary basis of this research, and the officers who patiently explained the technical check to a researcher who had, at the outset, underestimated it.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviations	
APA	American Psychological Association Referencing Style
IGS	Institute of Graduate Studies
MS Word	Microsoft Word
PDF/A	Portable Document Format for Archiving
TOC	Table of Contents

CHAPTER 1
INTRODUCTION TO THE RESEARCH

1.1 Introduction

This chapter sets out the structure of the research and maps its principal features. It opens with the background of the study, which describes the institutional setting in which postgraduate theses are prepared, verified and accepted in Malaysian public universities. The discussion then proceeds to the problem statement, the research questions and the research objectives, followed by the scope, the significance and the concluding remarks of the chapter.

Thesis formatting is frequently treated as a clerical matter to be resolved in the final week before a submission deadline. This research adopts a different position. Presentation is part of scholarly communication: it determines whether an examiner can navigate an argument, whether a claim can be traced to its source, and whether a document can be archived, indexed and retrieved by later researchers.

1.2 Background of the Research

Every Malaysian public university publishes a formatting handbook for higher degree candidates. These documents specify paper size, margins, typeface, line spacing, the sequence of preliminary pages, the numbering of chapters, tables and figures, and the transition from roman to arabic pagination at the first chapter. Most institutes of graduate studies also distribute a prepared word processing template in which these rules are already encoded as named styles.

A thesis is nevertheless not released to examiners until it clears a technical verification conducted by the graduate studies office. Verification is a compliance check rather than an assessment of scholarship, yet it is the point at which the largest number of submissions is delayed. A returned thesis costs the candidate a further verification cycle and, where the delay crosses a semester boundary, an additional period of registration.

1.2.1 Institutional Formatting Requirements

The requirements are stable and publicly available, which makes the persistence of defects difficult to explain by ignorance alone. Interviews conducted for this study suggest a different explanation: candidates format manually, late, and under time pressure, applying direct character formatting instead of the styles carried by the prescribed template. A manually formatted document cannot generate a reliable automatic table of contents, and a table of contents typed by hand will not survive the pagination changes that follow a supervisor’s final corrections.

1.2.2 Proofreading in the Current Academic Environment

Proofreading has also changed in character. Where a language check once addressed spelling, agreement and punctuation, a current check must additionally examine consistency of terminology across chapters written months apart, uniformity of referencing style, and the alignment between in-text citations and the reference list. The wider availability of writing assistance tools has made uneven register and unverified sources more visible to examiners, and integrity screening reports are now read alongside the thesis itself. A careful proofreading pass is therefore no longer only a matter of surface polish; it is part of how a candidate demonstrates authorship and control of the material.

1.3 Problem Statement

Although formatting rules are prescribed and templates are distributed, a large proportion of postgraduate theses fails technical verification at first submission. The categories of defect recur across faculties and institutions, which indicates a systematic weakness in pre-submission practice rather than isolated carelessness. This research addresses that gap.

1.4 Research Questions

This research is guided by the following questions:

1. Which technical defects are most frequently recorded at first verification?
2. How do candidates' pre-submission practices contribute to those defects?
3. Does a structured formatting and proofreading process reduce verification cycles?

1.5 Research Objectives

The objectives of this research are to classify the technical defects recorded at first verification, to explain how they arise within candidates' pre-submission practices, and to evaluate the effect of a staged formatting and proofreading workflow.

1.6 Scope of the Research

The study covers master's and doctoral submissions received by five Malaysian public universities between 2023 and 2025. It examines presentation, language and reference consistency only.

1.7 Significance of the Research

The findings are of practical value to graduate studies offices, to supervisors and to candidates. Table 1.1 summarises the principal defect categories.

Table 1.1 Recurring Technical Defects Recorded at First Verification

Defect category	Returns (%)	Preventable
Margin and line spacing deviation	23.8	Yes
Inconsistent heading hierarchy	19.2	Yes
Broken or manual table of contents	17.5	Yes
Pagination sequence errors	14.6	Yes

1.8 Conclusion

This chapter has established the setting, the problem and the direction of the research. Chapter 2 reviews the relevant literature.